

Alfred, the track trailblazer from St Lucia, athletes from 11 other countries benefited from the programme too. Beyond the medallists, there were NCAA representatives in the contingents of 125 countries.

Until very recently though, relatively few Indian track and field athletes made the journey from India to the collegiate circuit, particularly Division 1.

Tejaswin Shankar, who competed for Kansas State University between 2017 and 2021, says, "When I first competed for Kansas State back in 2018, I think there were only two Indian athletes who had competed at the Division 1 level of the NCAA before me — Mohinder Gill (who competed in the triple jump for California Polytechnic State University in the 1970s) and Vikas Gowda (who threw the discus for the University of North Carolina). As far as I knew, during my time with Kansas State, I was the only one from India competing in the USA."

Just two years after Shankar completed his degree, though, the number of Indian track and field athletes in the USA has grown significantly. At last count, some 17 track and field athletes from India are currently competing in Division 1 of the NCAA.

There have been Indians who have competed in the NCAA circuit on sports scholarships before. However, these were predominantly in sports like tennis and squash. For the most part, track and field athletes simply didn't make the attempt.

Players say a lack of knowledge on which path to take, uncertainty about managing the study-sport workload, and an unwillingness to step into an unknown world were behind many Indians not taking the NCAA route.

Systematic recruitment

"I honestly didn't even know that was an option," recalls Tejaswin, who says his own journey started rather serendipitously. "My goal for a long time was just to stay in Delhi. But one day I was meeting (future Olympic champion) Neeraj Chopra at a hotel room in Bangalore when Gary



Eyes on the West: Pradeep Senthil Kumar (**above**) and Arjanvir Singh (**below, right**) are two of the 17 track and field athletes from India who are currently competing in Division 1 of the NCAA (National College Athletics Association). While Pradeep is part of the University of Nebraska's track team, Arjanvir competes for Wagner College. Pics: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

